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THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Conversation with Helmut Kohl,
Chancellor of Germany

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Helmut Kohl, Chancellor
Brian Mulroney, Prime Minister
Interpreter: Gisela Marcuse
Notetaker: Robert Hutchings, NSC Staff

DATE, TIME August 26, 1991, 8:28 - 8:51 a.m.
AND PLACE: Kennebunkport, Maine

The President: Hello. How are you? (U)

Chancellor Kohl: Good, thanks. I am glad to hear your voice. I wanted to call briefly to discuss the present situation and also talk to you about an appointment. It seems the situation in Moscow is rather ambiguous. Obviously if individual republics gain their sovereignty and independence, I assume it will be a lot more difficult to talk with them. I am a little afraid that in the end there will be all sorts of discussions about borders - - for example, Moldavia's relationship to Romania -- which is why I tend to be rather careful and not to advance too quickly but to look at the situation carefully. I must say I am not quite sure about the real situation with Gorbachev. I don't know whether it is indeed the case that Yeltsin wants to assume his position or whether the secession of the Russian Republic is definite and absolute. Therefore, it is difficult and also ambiguous during this situation of transition. It is of the utmost importance that we remain in the closest possible contact. If you agree, I suggest we call at regular intervals in the next few days. What are your views? (C)

The President: I agree that we should stay in closest possible touch. Second, we have been taking a cautious line because, like you, we don't know yet how it will work out between Gorbachev and Yeltsin. The more immediate question for you and me is the recognition of the Baltic states. I don't know what you are going to do, but I am thinking about it right now. Incidentally, Brian Mulroney is visiting me now. I know we will have a Sherpa's meeting and also a meeting of finance ministers. (C)

Chancellor Kohl: It is a good thing that the Sherpas meet there to discuss in a calm and relaxed atmosphere all aspects of the situation, although it is even more complicated now to talk about possible aid when we don't know the set-up. (C)

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The President: That's why I urge caution. I agree that we should take stock of the situation before writing large checks. It is good to discuss the situation, but I told our Sherpa I want no commitments by the U.S. until we can sort out the situation. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: That's exactly my position. I am ready to help, but I must know for what. I must say the picture is rather unclear as far as reforms are concerned. It was much clearer in London. (Ø)

The President: Exactly! That is my view. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: We must look very carefully at what the next few days bring. It is good to let the meetings go forward, but we should be very cautious and not pin enormous hopes on these meetings. That could give rise to false expectations. On the second question you mentioned, the Baltic states, I do think we will see a climax during this week. Tomorrow the three foreign ministers of the Balts will meet with their EC counterparts. I think probably this week we will see a majority of the EC members opt for recognition. That corresponds to my view, although it is very clear to me that will give rise to enormous economic problems. I also foresee the enormous psychological effect this will have on the situation in Yugoslavia. (Ø)

The President: Yep. Helmut, has France recognized Baltic independence? (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: I think I can see a lot of movement in that direction. Francois in this matter has enormous problems on the domestic front. I think, if you agree, it would be a good idea for me to call again at 3:00 p.m. our time, that is 9:00 your time because I think by that time I will have more information from Paris. (Ø)

The President: That is OK with me. I don't know what we will do today. The same pressures you referred to in France are also present in Canada and here, too. If you are certain the EC will not go off individually and recognize the Balts today, it will give me more time. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: George, I cannot guarantee that. I can try to gather a little more information in the next three hours and relay the information back to the White House. (Ø)

The President: That would be very helpful. I don't have to do anything before 1:00 or 2:00 p.m. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: George, let's do it that way. Either I will call personally or one of my staff will call your staff. (U)

The President: Good. Antall of Hungary is calling me probably to say that he will recognize. Kaifu is also calling. I think they will do the same. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: George, if we are both in agreement, we can call each other later. If we are in agreement, maybe we can announce recognition later today together. (Ø)

The President: Good. Mulroney is here. I think he will recognize later today. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: I'll call again in two to three hours. (Ø)

The President: OK. If we are not here, Brent Scowcroft will be here. We're going out on a boat. If the connection is not good, Brent Scowcroft can receive your call. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: OK, that is no problem. George, one further important point: I am thinking about perhaps coming to see you for 3 to 4 hours, because I will be in California in September to give a talk at the University of California. I have been promising them to come for years, but you know how it is. I keep on promising... (Ø)

The President: Exactly. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: I feel greatly honored. I will be there only briefly, but I also promised Ron Reagan that I would come and see him. So I thought I might leave at night on 16 September and make a special stop in Washington to see you, if that is agreeable. (Ø)

The President: The only thing that wouldn't be agreeable is if I am out of town. The door is wide open to you. I think I'll be in Washington then. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: I'll tell my people to get to your people and agree on dates. So, if it is possible for us to meet for 3 or 4 hours, I will be looking forward to seeing you again. There is a lot to discuss. Besides, it doesn't make a very good impression if I stop in the U.S. without seeing you. (Ø)

The President: I just checked my schedule. I will be in Washington on the 16th so perhaps we could have supper that night. We'll work out something. Brian Mulroney wants to say a quick hello. He's sitting here looking good. (Ø)

(Pause while connection is broken)

Prime Minister Mulroney: Hello, Helmut. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: Hello, Brian. (U)

Prime Minister Mulroney: Here I am down in Kennebunkport defending your interests. As soon as George Bush said I would talk, you slammed down the phone and hung up. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: It's not true. My suspicion is that you don't know how to operate the instrument. (Ø)

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Prime Minister Mulroney: It's a little too complicated for a Canadian. (C)

Chancellor Kohl: I hope you have a splendid time. Please give our best to your children. (C)

Prime Minister Mulroney: Will do. I look forward to seeing you and Hannelore soon. (U)

-- End of Conversation --

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